The Bridge

By Paula Cizmar

Moscow. Marina, walks across a long stone bridge. She looks toward the end of the bridge and suddenly slows down. (Perhaps to feed a bird or two? For blocking purposes this was used to define the area where she is by the bridge . . . the office set up is straightforward enough with setting pieces.)

MARINA: I like this bridge. It goes over the Moscow River.

It ends up at St. Basils.

My office is near.

This is my favorite part,

In the wintertime, the pond is frozen, people are skating.

In spring, the leaves are just coming out --- It's like a green smoke, around the trees. The leaves are not out yet, but you feel as if they are coming.

My favorite time is when it is snowing.

Snow makes it beautiful.

This is the time for me to put myself together.

To come to some harmony with myself.

Because if you are not in harmony with yourself, this is a very difficult job to do.

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INTRODUCTION

1993 Russia. Domestic violence is not classified as a crime. Victims are invisible. Their cries unheard. Until one woman, takes it upon herself to, at last, provide these victims with a voice and end the silence, beginning with a single hotline.

The Bridge. A documentary play by Paula Cizmar

MARINA: I'm thinking about my work.

I'm thinking about what I have to do.

Thinking about --- *(A telephone rings, sounding muffled, distant. Marina watches the river, trying to steady herself, trying to shake off a memory. Finally:)*

She never told me her name.

--- Crisis center for women. How may I help you?

Then she says,

WOMAN: --- *I heard you on the radio*

--- *My husband---my husband is beating me---*

MARINA: --- Tell me what is happening ---

WOMAN: --- *He has beaten me for twenty-six years.*

MARINA: --- Tell me your address.

WOMAN: --- *my husband is very powerful.*

MARINA: --- I will come and bring the police.

WOMAN: --- *You don't understand. If you call someone, he will find out* ---

MARINA: --- Tell me ---

WOMAN: --- *Before you can get to me, I will be dead.*

MARINA: She is one of the ones I could not save. *(Marina watches the river a moment, breathes in the cold air.)*

Walking over this bridge.

The time for me to evaluate

In 1995, statistics were published that said that Fourteen thousand women a year had been killed by their husbands in Russia.

Every hour in Russia, a woman dies due to domestic violence.

What am I going to do?

The Beginning --- No One Talks

It was post-Soviet times. So much was new to us. I am assigned to the

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Institute for Socioeconomic Studies for the Population, and we put together a survey about women's issues. We get two letters from women --- letters we don't know how to classify --- talking about things their husbands are doing to them. My administrator at the Institute says:

--- *You have just come across a case of domestic violence.*

I have never heard of this.

At my son's school --- Peter was seven years old ---

One morning I am talking to two other women --- I am doing this survey about domestic violence …

Both of them just freeze. Then they say,

--- *What do you mean, domestic violence?*

(To the audience.) When I was growing up in the Soviet Union, "domestic violence"---nobody talked of such things. We did not even have words for it. So I explain that it is . . . when husbands are controlling, jealous, when they put you down, isolating you. The psychological slowly comes to physical abuse.

--- both of them say they are abused. One for six years. One for ten.

I feel something sinking inside me.

The director of the Institute. She gives me an office and a phone.

And I start the domestic violence hotline --- actually I don't call it a hotline, I call it a trust line.

Because all the women who call can do is trust.

It is six months into my work; I get a call from a woman. Svetlana. *(Telephone rings.)*

--- Crisis center for Women. How may I help you?

SVETLANA: --- *I think my husband is going to kill me.*

It started when I told him I was pregnant.

I saw his eyes.

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It was like someone flipped a switch.

MARINA: Something about this call. I am scared for her.

SVETLANA: --- *When the baby was nine months old,*

I was holding the baby.

He came to me, and I didn't know what he was going to do.

He grabbed me by the hair and started beating my head against the wall.

I got to the bedroom and covered the baby with my body.

In the morning. He said he was drunk. He asked me to forgive him.

But this time, I said No.

No. I want a divorce.

He looked at me and said: I'll kill you.

--- I really believe him.

MARINA: So I call the police. I speak to the officer.

He says, *I will see what I can do.*

Next thing he does, he calls the husband.

(Marina back at the bridge.)

‹In Russia› *He beats you, therefore he loves you.* It's a saying that comes from the sixteenth century. It was called "*domostroi*." *Domostroi* were basically household rules.

These rules described how a man should punish his wife to make her more obedient.

Don't beat her on her face, because you won't be able to show her in public.

It's better to use the whip rather than a stick because it will be more painful so she will learn her lesson better.

He beats you, therefore he loves you. Since the sixteenth century it has been an excuse.

I didn't have much. My salary is not enough, and I don't know how I am going

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to feed my son.

One friend, she brings me a set of wonderful dishes. Very nice colors and cheerful. And I did need dishes. It was very thoughtful. But I look at her and say, I cannot accept this. And she says,

--- You know what, you have to learn to accept, not just give.

And this teaches me.

I start to realize I am supported by so many other people.

That keeps me going. It's a community.

When you grow up with love around you, that gives you internal freedom to share this love with others. It gives you an internal responsibility to share this love, and it gives you the ability to share it.

For the first few months, it was hard.

At one point my son came to me and said from now on, he's going to be taking care of me --- and I suddenly realize, I have to give him his childhood. I need to be strong for him.

So I say, No. You are still a boy. Someday, when you grow up, I will need your help. You will take care of me. But now, I will take care of us.

After work, I would get out of the subway and stop on the way and get something nice --- cookies or fruit, something to cheer us up, and then come home. *(A telephone rings. Distant.)*

But then, this guy starts calling me at home. He is watching me. And the thing is, he---See, threat calls on the hotline are very common. But this guy knows who I am and knows my home number.

So he calls and he says,

MAN: *Marina?*

Aren't you afraid to do what you are doing?

MARINA: I say, Excuse me, who are you?

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MAN: *I'm someone who was affected by your work.*

I know everything about you…

MARINA: ---Who are you?

MAN: *--- Aren't you afraid that your son is alone in the street?*

MARINA: That is the worst thing. I feel that somebody has stuck a knife in my heart.

He knows about my son.

I don't allow Peter to pick up the phone at home; I have my parents pick him up from school every day, he is never, never alone. I am scared.

He calls,

MAN: *--- I know where you live.*

--- Aren't you afraid for your son?

MARINA: Don't you dare touch my son, ever. Don't even think about it.

I know what he is doing. Control me. I try to use all my knowledge and skills not to play into this game.

I buy a phone with caller ID.

And when he calls, I say to him,

--- I've got your number. If you are not going to stop, I am going to the police.

Don't think things go unnoticed, unpunished. Don't.

And he hangs up.

And he never calls again.

My phone didn't identify his number totally.

I was bluffing.

But it was a great bluff. *(Marina huddles into herself, walking into the wind. She stops. Watches the river.)*

Last year a woman was killed and they were showing the story on TV. Her husband was beating her every night.

She died from the beating.

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Everybody knew this was going on for three years.

Why? Why did no one do anything?

Honestly, every time I hear about another case, I feel like I am back in 1993!

Violence is still going on!

What am I going to do? *(Marina watches the river flow by.)*

This bridge is called Bolshoi Moskvoretskiy ----

You have to be careful on this path. There is so much responsibility; there are so many people that matter.

Our work is not done yet. *(Marina -- into her office. A telephone rings.)*

--- Crisis Center for Women.

---What can I do for you?

---Can you tell me what happened?

---Tell me, please so that I can help. *(Another telephone rings.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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